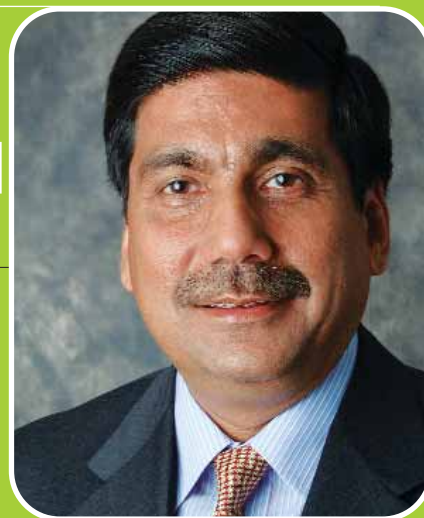


Mobility, Seamless Connectivity, And Convergence is the way ahead



R Zutshi

Dy Managing Director, Samsung India Electronics P. Ltd

With the plethora of new technologies and products being introduced in the market and consumers themselves becoming more and more demanding, companies are finding ways to make their approaches more simple. The most noticeable trends in the market today are therefore mobility, connectivity, and convergence. The distinction between PC, CE, and mobile phones is blurring. Thus, today, while on the one hand you have products like the Ultra Mobile PC (UMPC) in the market, you also see Full HD LCD TVs (with 1080p resolution) coming into the marketplace, with HDMI connections for connecting HD digital devices like disc players, game consoles, as well as cameras, camcorders, and laptops.

Today, one can see and experience easier syncing between mobile devices and PCs. Multimedia mobile devices with imaging, gaming, and video functionality, as well as mobile phones with integrated VoIP functionality are being introduced in markets the world over.

Depending on the government regulations of a particular country, Mobile phones with VoIP functionality or Mobile TV broadcasting are in different stages of introduction in different markets, the world over.

In this era of digital convergence, even as storing and transferring of video content across multiple devices (PC, DVR, etc.) is gaining popularity, one is also witnessing an increasing connectivity of home appliances. With USB Video Play feature in home theatres, today a user doesn't need to burn CDs or DVDs to enjoy music, video clips, or photos on his home theatre system. One just needs to plug a portable digital device into the USB port for instant entertainment.

Online gaming communities are becoming a phenomenon the world over just as blogging communities are emerging as a new force to reckon with. So what do all these changes imply? I believe that in the future, a user will be able to watch any content, anytime, anywhere in his/her home. The device used could be TV, PC, or phone.

In the mobile space, with the convergence of services becoming a reality, we could be looking at a situation where the device chooses the transmission method by itself, for content and occasion.

One of the most obvious fallouts of the digital convergence is that "hi-tech" is being redefined even as IT is being commoditised.

Formerly professional-grade products are now accessible to the consumer market—flat panels are now accessible at a price for homes, not just offices. Today, one is experiencing an explosive increase in demand for consumer-use semiconductors, with around 50 per cent of all semiconductor consumption to be used for consumer products by 2013.

Projectors, formerly used in offices, are being used for home theatres. Smartphones have started becoming more fashionable and slim to appeal to consumers. Notebooks are growing to adopt multimedia functions.

Thus, even as formerly enterprise-oriented products are now accessible in the consumer market, similarly, products / technologies that were originally consumer-oriented like VoIP, Wi-Fi, and the Internet are now being adopted by enterprises. "Consumerisation," I expect, will be the most influential IT trend for the next 10 years. In other words, I expect technology innovation will be driven by consumers, and business technology will be part of it.

Consumers will be interested in knowing how the new technologies can benefit them rather than knowing about the new technologies per se.

High-speed Internet connectivity is contributing significantly to the growth of Internet-based social networking. Mobile phone speeds are getting faster as consumers adopt 3G. Connection speed and business innovation are driving a new wave of consumer behaviour and interactivity. Consumers are reaching out more, sharing more, and creating more content for the Internet.

Today, from text to music and videos, users contribute and share almost everything that can be digitised. The Web 2.0 transition is lifting up user participation level, by way of increasing Internet access, content creation, and information retrieval.

Going forward, in the future, I think we can expect "Real" broadband access anytime, anywhere, as well as seamless integration of application based data on local Desktop and Web-based service.

I see the beginning of an era of seamless connectivity. Complexity is out—and simplicity is here to stay. ☒

Ravinder Zutshi became Deputy Managing Director, Samsung India Electronics Ltd, in April 2005. Mr Zutshi oversees the Consumer Electronics, Home Appliances and Information Technology business, along with Corporate Functions